EXECUTIVE BRIEFING · OPERATOR LAYER

MODULE 5 INSIDER PLAYBOOK — HUMAN FREQUENCY: The Relationship Ladder & Industry Etiquette

Frequency Dominion · Confidential Operating System

Executive briefing. The durable layer under the lessons. Read after 5.1–5.4.

THE RELATIONSHIP LADDER (MEMORIZE THE RUNGS)

Radio relationships move in ladder rungs. Every interaction should climb one rung — never skip, never stall:

Rung	Name	Definition	Your move
1	**Stranger**	No reply, no contact	The pitch
2	**Contact**	A reply — any reply	Answer fast, offer the call
3	**Conversation**	A 12-minute call	Listen 3 min, one ask, one next step
4	**Ally**	An add + thank-you + asset	Thank-you economy
5	**Champion**	Re-adds, upgrades, introduces you	Value drops, 2-way intros
6	**Confidant**	Shares feedback, format info, goes to bat	Monthly one-line check-ins, zero asks

The ladder is why Module 5's cadence exists: a call doesn't get you a champion; the **year** of correct stewardship does. Most artists stall at rung 3 (one call, then nothing) and call radio a closed door.

THE THANK-YOU MATRIX (WHAT LABELS ACTUALLY DO FOR THEIR CHAMPIONS)

The gesture hierarchy, keyed to rung:

- **Rung 4 (add):** specific 3-day thank-you + social clip tagging the station.
- **Rung 5 (upgrade/repeat):** 2-week asset (station ID, premiere, reserved tickets) + an on-air shout-out offer.
- **Rung 6 (champion):** 90-day value drop — no ask attached. Introduce them to an artist. Send a listener for the request line. Give them the story first.

The matrix's rule: **the gesture is always one rung above the ask.** If you want champion behavior, give confidant respect first. This inversion is the entire economy.

THE 12-MINUTE CALL: THE INSIDER SCRIPT QUEUE

Beyond the structure, the sequence of questions does the heavy lifting:

1. **The warm-up is bait, not small talk.** “What’s the most exciting thing that’s happened on [show] this month?” Their answer is a gift: it tells you exactly what they’re proud of — and what to reference forever after.
2. **The format question is a market scan.** “What does a new record need to do to fit here?” The answer contains their internal criteria — their wording — which you can mirror in every future pitch.
3. **The timing question is a calendar unlock.** “When’s your add cycle and what day does rotation go out?” Answers set your next campaign’s dates.
4. **The ask is the smallest possible thing.** One slot. One show. One recheck date. The call’s goal is the next step, not the commitment.

Golden rule: never end a call without a next step and a date. No next step = no relationship. The 12-minute call that ends in a date becomes rung 3 → rung 4 in 72 hours.

THE INDUSTRY ETIQUETTE CODE (VIOLATIONS THAT BURN WELLS)

- **Never pitch another record in the same conversation as a thank-you.** The thank-you is its own message. Momentum is not a coupon.
- **Never ask a PD for a separate favor (press, playlist, social) in the same ask.** Radio owes you one thing per cycle. One ask, one cycle.
- **Never argue about a “no.”** A “not now” is a calendar answer, not a judgment. A polite “understood, checking back in [month]” converts a no into a recheck — which is a win disguised as a rejection.
- **Never use the words “sorry to bother you” or “I know you’re busy.”** You’re telling the PD their attention is a burden. They know. It’s the ask that matters.
- **Never send a gift with an ask attached.** The gift is the message.
- **Never share another artist’s private contact or a promo rep’s list.** The industry is small; leaks travel fast and kill trust permanently.

THE BURNED-WELL TRIAGE (POINTERS FROM THE REPLAY)

Repair priority is return-on-effort, not guilt:

- **Highest ROI:** the well you ghosted (a promise unkept). One honest bridge can recover a full ally in a month.
- **High ROI:** the well you spammed (blasted, went quiet). 90-day cooling + clean signal + new value. Slow but recoverable.
- **Medium ROI:** the clash well (pitched a mismatch, argued). Only recover if the format changed or a new MD arrived — check the playlist first.
- **Low ROI:** the value-debt well (got a yes, gave nothing back). Recover via a genuine giving period — and this one actually improves you: it’s a discipline lesson, not a repair.

Never re-pitch a well before its cooling period ends. Never re-pitch with the same angle. Two violations and the well is permanent.

THE INTRO-WEB MULTIPLIER (THE CONFIDANT MOVE)

The highest-value relationship move in the entire system: **introduce two of your contacts who benefit each other.** The PD gets a useful connection, you get network gravity, and the rung you climb is irrelevant — you become a node of value. Two intros a month builds a confidant network faster than fifty emails. When your next record drops, the intros you made are the credits you’ve banked.

THE ONE SECRET MOST ARTISTS NEVER LEARN

A PD’s time is the only inventory they can’t restock — and they notice who respects it. The 12-minute call, the 3-touch stop, the one-ask rule, and the thank-you economy aren’t politeness; they’re a demonstration that you understand the inventory. That understanding is what makes a PD think of you when a specialty slot opens, a local spot opens, or a new-music hour needs a guest. The relationship isn’t the ask. The relationship is the respect for the clock.

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